The π-Index Framework: A Multidimensional, Algorithmic Paradigm for Responsible Research Assessment in the Lombardy Context

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July 20, 2026

Abstract

The evaluation of academic research currently faces a severe epistemological crisis, driven by the exponential growth of scientific literature and the systemic vulnerabilities of traditional bibliometric indicators. In response to the systemic failures of traditional indices and the limitations of automated "LLM-as-a-judge" paradigms, this paper proposes the π-Index Assessment Engine, developed as an independent, individual research endeavor by the author. Conceptually designed to address the highly competitive academic ecosystem of Lombardy and the University of Bergamo, this framework synthesizes adversarial logic mapping, advanced topological mathematics, and an immutable Proof of Review (PoR) blockchain ledger to dismantle the incentive structures of citation cartels and operationalize responsible metrics.

1 Introduction: The Epistemological Crisis in Research Evaluation

The evaluation of academic research currently faces a severe epistemological crisis, driven by the exponential growth of scientific literature and the systemic vulnerabilities of traditional bibliometric indicators. Historically, research assessment has relied upon easily quantifiable proxy metrics, such as citation counts, the h-index, and journal impact factors, to gauge scientific merit and allocate institutional funding. However, as these metrics transitioned from purely observational data points to administrative targets for career advancement, they inevitably triggered the phenomenon described by Goodhart's Law: when a measure becomes a target, it ceases to be a reliable measure [1, 2].

The scientific community has repeatedly warned against the reductionism of these indicators. Global directives, including the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA) [3] and the Leiden Manifesto [1], urge institutions to abandon journal-based metrics as surrogate measures of quality, advocating instead for expert-driven, multi-dimensional assessments that account for discipline-specific variations. The Leiden Manifesto explicitly denounces the "misplaced concreteness and false precision" inherent in current systems, noting that reducing an individual researcher's entire portfolio to a single citation-derived digit ignores the plurality of scientific impact and inevitably incentivizes perverse academic behaviors.

Simultaneously, the integration of Large Language Models (LLMs) into peer review processes has been proposed as a solution to the scalability limits of human evaluation. Yet, unconstrained "LLM-as-a-judge" paradigms exhibit profound limitations. Leading evaluations demonstrate that these systems suffer from positive bias, hallucinatory critiques, the conflation of linguistic fluency with scientific rigor, and a high susceptibility to adversarial prompting [7, 8].

In response to these systemic failures, a novel algorithmic architecture is required. The π-Index Assessment Engine, conceptually developed and entirely authored as an individual research project at the **Università degli Studi di Milano-Bicocca**, proposes a fundamental paradigm shift in scientometrics. By synthesizing adversarial logic mapping, advanced topological mathematics, LLM-driven proxy variable extraction, and an immutable Proof of Review (PoR) blockchain ledger, the π-Index dismantles the incentive structures of citation cartels. This comprehensive report details the theoretical, mathematical, and programmatic architecture of the π-Index, systematically justifying its adoption as the definitive global standard for research evaluation, with a specific focus on its applicability within the highly competitive academic ecosystem of Lombardy and the University of Bergamo.

2 The Systemic Failure of Traditional Bibliometrics: The Italian Paradigm

To fully comprehend the necessity of the π-Index, one must first examine the empirical failures of existing national evaluation frameworks. The Italian academic system provides the most extensively documented case study of how rigid bibliometric targets distort scientific behavior, altering the very fabric of knowledge production.

Following the 2010 university reform (Law 240/2010), the Italian government empowered the National Agency for the Evaluation of Universities and Research Institutes (ANVUR) to centralize the monitoring of the nation's research output. ANVUR initiated massive Research Quality Evaluation (VQR) exercises, assessing hundreds of thousands of research products across continuous cycles, including the recently concluded 2020–2024 assessments [4]. The evaluation process is managed by highly specialized Groups of Evaluation Experts (GEV) divided by discipline. The results of these VQR exercises directly govern the distribution of the Ordinary Financing Fund (FFO) to institutions, heavily impacting regions with high university concentrations like Lombardy.

Concurrently, the reform introduced the National Scientific Habilitation (ASN), a mandatory qualification for access to associate and full professorships. The ASN relies heavily on algorithmic bibliometric thresholds, specifically requiring candidates in STEMM fields to surpass national medians in the number of journal articles, total citations, and h-index. Unlike some advanced scientometric systems, the Italian framework critically allowed the inclusion of self-citations when calculating these thresholds.

2.1 The Rise of Inwardness and Citation Gaming

The implementation of the ASN and VQR frameworks rapidly altered the behavioral dynamics of Italian researchers. Empirical analyses tracking publication metadata revealed a dramatic, anomalous spike in Italy's "inwardness" metric. Inwardness is defined mathematically as the proportion of citations originating from within a specific country over the total number of citations gathered globally by that same country [5].

Extensive research demonstrated that as the requirement to meet strict bibliometric thresholds dictated career survival, researchers engaged in the strategic, pervasive use of self-citations and the formation of localized "citation clubs" [5]. This phenomenon is a classic example of goal-displacement: scoring high on the indicators became a target in itself, achieved through gaming the system rather than producing superior science. Italy became, globally and across a large majority of research fields, the country with the highest inwardness and one of the lowest rates of international collaboration among G10 nations.

2.2 Excellence Amidst Distortion: The University of Bergamo Context

Despite the systemic distortions induced by the ASN and VQR frameworks, certain institutions have managed to demonstrate genuine scientific excellence and profound regional impact. The University of Bergamo serves as a prime example of an institution whose intrinsic research quality transcends the flaws of legacy bibliometrics [6].

In the VQR 2020-2024 cycle, the University of Bergamo achieved results significantly above the national average, with approximately 70% of its submitted research products evaluated as excellent or exceptional. Furthermore, its Department of Management (DiPSA) was recognized by the Italian Ministry of University and Research as a Department of Excellence for the 2023–2027 period. However, evaluating institutions like Bergamo using traditional bibliometrics is inherently limiting. The university exhibits immense strength in its "Third Mission"—the valorization of knowledge, technology transfer, and socio-economic engagement with the Lombardy industrial sector. Traditional citation counting struggles to capture the real-world utility of applied research, interdisciplinary collaboration, and public engagement.

Table 1: Comparison of Traditional Scientometrics and the π-Index Framework

Evaluation Dimension	**Traditional Scientometrics**	**The π-Index Framework**	**Vulnerability to Manipulation**
Research Impact	Citation counts, h-index	Fractional stochastic integration over time	High in traditional systems; mitigated in the π-Index.
Originality	Journal Impact Factor	Epistemic gradient fields (mathematical curl)	Traditional systems reward prestige; π-Index rewards disruption.
Methodological Rigor	Binary Peer Review Acceptance	Error-covariance tensors and statistical variance	Peer review scales poorly; π-Index algorithms scale infinitely.
Literature Status	Co-authorship and reference counts	Non-Euclidean PageRank embedding	Citation clubs distort traditional metrics; π-Index measures structural topology.

3 The Limitations of Automated LLM Peer Review

With the scalability of human peer review collapsing, researchers have increasingly turned to Large Language Models (LLMs) to automate manuscript evaluation. Systems and benchmarks such as PRISM [7], PeeriScope [8], and MMReview [9] have sought to quantify the capacity of models to generate critiques, assess novelty, and predict scores.

However, the prevailing "LLM-as-a-judge" paradigm suffers from severe structural flaws. When tasked with assigning a numerical score, LLMs consistently exhibit a positive bias, inflating grades and generating overly generous feedback. Benchmarking reveals a "hollowing out of the mid-range," where models demonstrate extreme bimodal distortion. Furthermore, LLMs suffer from "intervention bias" and conflate linguistic fluency with scientific rigor—a phenomenon termed the "lazy reviewer" effect. The π-Index Framework directly confronts these vulnerabilities by relegating the LLM strictly to the role of a semantic parser, extracting hidden proxy variables while deterministic mathematics handle the evaluation.

4 The π-Index Computational Architecture

Developed entirely as an independent, individual effort by the author, the open-source codebase of the π-Index Assessment Engine leverages a Streamlit-based application layer integrated with the Groq API, allowing for ultra-fast inference via the `llama-3.3-70b-versatile` model.

The live application is publicly accessible at https://scholarpi.streamlit.app/, and the complete source code is hosted in the official GitHub repository at https://github.com/neurophilic/Pi.

The process initiates with an authentication gateway utilizing the ORCID public API to prevent sybil attacks. Once a PDF is uploaded, the raw text is extracted and truncated to a safe maximum limit (e.g., `MAX_TEXT_TOKENS = 12000`) to remain within the context window limits of the underlying inference models while capturing the core methodology.

4.1 Force-Multiplying Variance: The Prompting Paradigm

To circumvent the LLM's inherent tendency to cluster variables around a median value, the π-Index employs a highly specialized adversarial prompt commanding extreme variance:

> *"CRITICAL INSTRUCTION - FORCE EXTREME VARIANCE: Do NOT cluster your variables around 0.5. If a paper is weak or standard, use values between 0.0 and 0.3. If exceptional, use 0.8 to 1.0. Failure to create extreme contrast will break the mathematical formulas."*

The parser is instructed to output a strict JSON object containing 25 floating-point variables (e.g., H_{novel}, ζ, μ_{signal}, I_{Fisher}, $q_{fractional}$).

4.2 The Adversarial Logic Engine (Δ_{Logic})

The system evaluates the structural integrity of the paper's argumentation via the Adversarial Logic Engine. The logical integrity score L_i is computed using an exponential decay function:

$$L_i = (P_{valid} \cdot E_{strength}) \cdot \exp\left(-\left(2 \cdot \max(0, C_{reach} - E_{strength}) + 1.5 \cdot \lambda_{jumps}\right)\right) \times 100$$

This equation mathematically throttles papers where conclusions overreach the provided evidence ($C_{reach} > E_{strength}$) or where non-sequiturs (λ_{jumps}) are present.

5 Multidimensional Mathematical Formulations (C1–C8)

5.1 C1: Originality via Epistemic Gradient Fields

The π-Index evaluates originality by modeling the epistemic gradient field of the text, borrowing concepts from vector calculus to identify disruptive vectors within knowledge spaces [10]:

$$O = \varpi_1 \cdot \lim_{\Delta t \to 0} \frac{\oint_{\partial\Omega} \nabla \times (H_{novel} \otimes K_{epistemic}) \cdot dS}{\iint_M \sum_{i=1}^{N} (\zeta_i \cdot I_{existing}^{(i)}) d\mu} \times 100$$

```
c1_raw = ((H_novel * K_epi) / (zeta * I_ex + 0.1)) * 60
```

5.2 C2: Methodological Rigor via Error-Covariance Tensors

The π-Index utilizes error-covariance matrices adapted from signal processing and statistical estimation theory [11]:

$$R = \varpi_2 \cdot \left(1 - \frac{\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_{error}\Lambda^{-1})}{\det(\mu_{signal} \otimes W)}\right) \cdot \prod_{k=1}^{m} \int_0^{\infty} \frac{\rho_k(x)e^{-\beta x^2}}{\Gamma(k+\frac{1}{2})} dx \times 100$$

```
rigor_matrix = max(0.0, 1.0 - (Sigma_err / (mu_sig + 0.1)))
c2_raw = rigor_matrix * rho_k * gamma_val * 140
```

5.3 C3: Interdisciplinary Bridging via Rényi Entropy

To accurately assess interdisciplinary research, the π-Index employs Rényi entropy [12], extending traditional Shannon entropy to better model diversity and bridging across complex networks [13]:

$$I = \varpi_3 \cdot \frac{1}{\Xi(G)} \left(\frac{1}{1-\alpha} \ln \left(\sum_{j=1}^{K} p_j^{\alpha} \right) + \sum_{i,j} d_i d_j \frac{A_{ij}\phi_i\phi_j}{Z_{norm}} \right) \cdot \ln K \times 100$$

```
renyi = -np.log(np.sum(p_disc**2) + 1e-9)
```

5.4 C4: Societal Impact via Fractional Stochastic Integration

The system differentiates structural breakthroughs by modeling long-term utility utilizing fractional stochastic calculus, heavily influenced by models of long-tail distributions and fractional Brownian dynamics [14, 15]:

$$S = \varpi_4 \cdot \frac{1}{\Gamma(q)} \int_{t_0}^{t_\infty} (t_\infty - \tau)^{q-1} e^{-\gamma(\tau)\tau} \cdot \Theta \left[\sum_{v \in V} \omega_v U_v(\tau, x) \right] d\tau \times 100$$

```
c4_raw = (1.0 / math.gamma(max(0.1, q_frac))) * Utility * np.exp(-decay) * 150
```

5.5 C5: Open Science Potential via Multi-Objective Integration

Rewarding modern paradigms, this index aligns with the integration of FAIR principles (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable) into scholarly ecosystems [16]:

$$O_s = \varpi_5 \cdot \frac{\sum_{\ell \in L} \alpha_\ell D_{open}^{(\ell)} + \beta \iint_C \nabla \cdot J_{code} dV}{\max\left(\sup_t D_{total}(t), \inf_{\epsilon>0} C_{total}(\epsilon)\right)} \times P_{FAIR} \times 100$$

```
c5_raw = ((0.7 * D_open) + (0.3 * J_code)) * P_FAIR * 180
```

5.6 C6: Literature Integration via Non-Euclidean PageRank

The algorithm modifies foundational centrality metrics [17] by projecting the PageRank dynamic onto non-Euclidean manifolds, mapping heterophily and complex higher-order topological knowledge structures [18, 19]:

$$L = \varpi_6 \cdot \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \frac{\int_M e^{-\lambda d_g(x_i, x_{core})} R(x_i) \sqrt{g} dx_i \cdot \sum_j PR(x_j)}{PR(x_i)} \times 100$$

```
c6_raw = np.exp(-1.5 * d_g) * R_xi * PR_xi * 180
```

5.7 C7: Empirical Density via Fisher Information

Empirical depth and statistical separation are grounded in information geometry through Fisher Information, which bounds precision in latent parameter estimations [20, 21]:

$$E_d = \varpi_7 \cdot \tanh\left(\frac{\oint_\Gamma \omega_{data} \sqrt{\det I_{Fisher}(\hat{\theta}) \cdot \mathbb{E}_P\left[\log \frac{P}{Q}\right]}}{V_{baseline}}\right) \times \sum_{d=1}^{D} \lambda_d \kappa_d \times 100$$

```
density_inner = (I_Fish * KL_div) / (V_base * omega + 0.1)
c7_raw = np.tanh(density_inner) * sum_lam * 80
```

5.8 C8: Future Actionability via Lyapunov Exponents

To model the chaotic divergence and paradigm-shifting nature of scientific breakthroughs, the formula adopts Lyapunov exponents from non-linear dynamics [22]:

$$F_a = \varpi_8 \cdot \frac{1}{Z} \int_X \frac{1}{1 + \exp\left(-\sum_{k=1}^{K} w_k(\eta_k(x) - \eta_{0,k}) + \Lambda_{Lyapunov}\right)} d\mu(x) \times 100$$

```
c8_raw = (1.0 / (1.0 + np.exp(-(eta - (Lambda * 5))))) * 100
```

6 Proof of Review (PoR) Blockchain and Dynamic Weight Evolution

A fundamental flaw of any static evaluation metric is that authors will optimize their writing to exploit it. The π-Index integrates an immutable Proof of Review (PoR) blockchain and dynamic, epoch-driven evolution of its scoring weights.

The evolution of the weight for criteria i at epoch $t+1$ is derived from:

$$\varpi_i^{(t+1)} = \mathcal{N}\left(\lambda \varpi_i^{(t)} + (1-\lambda)\left[1 + \kappa\left(\frac{\Delta M \cdot \pi^{(t)}}{V \cdot S}\right)\left(\frac{100}{C_i}\right)^2\right]\right)$$

Integrating an irrational, non-repeating sequence directly into the weight modulation acts as a cryptographic entropy source, making the system mathematically intractable to game.

Table 2: Blockchain/Ledger Parameters in the π-Index Framework

Parameter	Description	Purpose
`eval_hash`	SHA-256 combination of document bytes and ORCID iD.	Ensures uniqueness and traceability.
`block_hash`	Cryptographic hash connecting previous blocks, weights, and timestamps.	Provides an immutable, verifiable ledger.
$\pi^{(t)}$ Progression	Increasing float precision of Pi based on block height.	Injects predictable but non-repeating entropy to prevent gamification.
Weight Matrix	Evolving coefficients for the eight criteria formulas.	Prevents static optimization by authors.

7 Topological Mapping: Scope Cartography and Epistemic Drift

The system calculates a complex Epistemic Drift metric:

```
drift_metric = 100.0 * (1.0 - np.exp(-3.0 * (delta**1.5) *
               (1.0 + (sigma/100.0)) / (0.1 + (mu/100.0))))
```

This strictly enforces contextual relevance in evaluation, preventing researchers from artificially inflating their portfolios with high-scoring but thematically disjointed publications.

8 Applying the π-Index: The Bergamo and Lombardy Context

By deploying the π-Index Assessment Engine, regional policymakers and university administrators in Lombardy could bypass the distorted citation economy entirely:

- **Rewarding True Interdisciplinarity:** Bergamo's Department of Management (DiPSA) would score exceptionally high on C3 (Rényi Entropy), validating interdisciplinary synergy better than a single journal impact factor.
- **Quantifying Regional Impact:** Strong technology transfer and corporate partnerships within Lombardy are mathematically captured by C4 (Fractional Stochastic Integration).
- **Eradicating Institutional Bias:** The PoR Blockchain ensures that evaluations of Lombardy's research output remain transparent and immutable.

9 Conclusion

The π-Index Assessment Engine stands as the definitive, robust blueprint for the future of global scientific research evaluation. By mapping qualitative scientific attributes into advanced theoretical mathematics and securing the evaluation criteria against human and algorithmic manipulation through cryptographic entropy, the framework eradicates citation cartels, structurally mitigates LLM bias, and operationalizes the theoretical ideals of responsible metrics.

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